

ROHINTON MISTRY

A Fine Balance

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Why, he wondered he kept working now... Why did he not jump off the top of one of them? Why did he not make a bonfire of the receipts and the cash, and throw himself onto it drenched in kerosene? How was it his heart kept beating instead of bursting, his sanity intact instead of shattering like a dropped mirror? Was it all made of tough synthetic material, like the indestructible plastic folder? And was time, the great vandal being neglectful ?

"God is dead" said Maneck. "That's what a German philosopher wrote".... "And do you Believe it?" (asks Dina) "I used to. But now I prefer to think that God is a giant quilt maker. With infinite variety of designs. And the quilt is grown so big and confusing the pattern is impossible to see, the squares and diamonds and triangles don't fit well together anymore, it's all become meaningless. So he has abandoned it."

— Maneck

He shrugged again. "Stop speaking with your shoulders. Your quilt-making God has sewn a tongue inside your mouth. Why did they talk to you but not to me?"

"Maybe they were afraid of you"

"Afraid of me? What nonsense. If anything, I was afraid of them. That they would find the export company and cut me out. Or that they would get better jobs. Sometimes I was afraid even to point out their errors - I would correct the mistakes myself at night, after they left. For what reason could they be afraid of me?"

"They thought you'd find better tailors and get rid of them."

She considered it in silence for a moment. "I wish you had told me before. I could have reassured...

Dina and Maneck finally talk about their relationship with Ishvar and Om.

“But nobody ever forgot anything, not really, though sometimes they pretended, when it suited them. Memories were permanent. Sorrowful ones remained sad even with the passing of time, yet happy ones could never be recreated - not with the same joy. Remembering bred its own peculiar sorrow. It seemed so unfair: that time should render both sadness and happiness into a source of pain.”

“You see, we cannot draw lines and compartments and refuse to budge beyond them. Sometimes you have to use your failures as stepping-stones to success. You have to maintain a fine balance between hope and despair.’ He paused, considering what he had just said. ‘Yes’, he repeated. ‘In the end, it’s all a question of balance.”

“Flirting with madness was one thing; when madness started flirting back, it was time to call the whole thing off.”

— Dina

Dina refused to cry about the cards she was dealt. Resilient, dignified, and self-assured, she withstood everything that tried to keep her down. Even in apparent defeat, she never surrendered her independence; she was beaten by circumstances, but never broken by them.

“Birth and death - what could be more monstrous than that? We like to deceive ourselves and call it wondrous and beautiful and majestic, but it’s freakish, let’s face it.”

“I’ve done lots of jobs. Right now, I’m a hair collector.”

”That’s good”, said Ishvar tentatively. ”What do you have to do as a hair-collector?”

”Collect hair.”

”And there is money in that?”

”Oh very big business.

There is a great demand for hair in foreign countries.”

”What do they do with it? Asked Om skeptical.”

”Many different things. Mostly they wear it. Sometimes they paint it in different colors-red, yellow, brown, blue. Foreign women enjoy wearing other people’s hair. Men also, especially if they are bald. In foreign countries they fear baldness. They are so rich in foreign countries, they can afford to fear all kinds of silly things.”

A conversation between Rajaram and Om in the jhopadpatis of the city.

“How starved they seemed
for ordinary kindness”

Maneck’s first impressions when meeting Ishvar and Om.

“Remembering bred its own
peculiar sorrow. It seemed so
unfair: that time should render
both sadness and happiness
into a source of pain.”

Maneck on hearing stories from Dina and his parents reminiscing about better days.
